

of milk. Rather than pursuing Saraswati, they pursue Lakshmi. They delude themselves that acquisition of Lakshmi will make them immortal and all-powerful. They do not realise that despite having Lakshmi, Devas are insecure and eternally anxious.

And so, an Asura called Hiranayaksha drags Bhu-devi, the earth-goddess, to the bottom of the sea and claims her for himself. He declares himself to be her master. This is delusion. The earth belongs to no one. To claim ownership of her, or parts of her, stems from ignorance.

The abduction of Bhu-devi by Hiranayaksha alarms the Devas who complain to their father, Brahma. Brahma hears Bhu-devi's wailing. In rage, Brahma's nostrils flare. From one of the flaring nostrils emerges a wild boar with long resplendent tusks. It is Vishnu in the form of Varaha!

Varaha plunges into the sea and challenges the Asura, Hiranayaksha, to a duel. The fight is fierce as Hiranayaksha clings to Bhu-devi, refusing to let her go. But in the end, Varaha gores him to death. Varaha then rises up towards the surface, holding Bhu-devi on his snout. The goddess sings songs praising Vishnu. She declares him Bhu-pati, the lord of earth, her husband. He promises to take care of her. 'If anyone treats you with disrespect, they will answer to me,' says Vishnu.

From that day, Vishnu becomes the guardian of earth, watching over Bhu-devi, stretching himself as the sky above. That is why Vishnu is blue as the day-sky and black as the night-sky.



Some say that, as they rose, Bhu-devi accepted Varaha as her consort and named him Bhu-pati, lord of the earth. They made love and so passionate was Vishnu's embrace that the